ANTI-MUSLIM SENTIMENT AND DISENFRANCHISEMENT

Anti-Muslim sentiment in Myanmar is not a novelty of the political transition, but results from the country's historical ethno-linguistic complexity. Expressions of Buddhist nationalism earned integral status in Burmese politics during the anti-colonial struggle. Religious legitimation of political power was relevant for all regimes following independence — parliamentary, socialist, and military. This continues to be so both for state and opposition leaders of the Burmese mainstream (Schober 2006, p. 91). Those who are perceived as foreigners — including Indians, Chinese, and Muslims — were often targeted in times of political crisis. Extremist expression and violence linked to Buddhist-inspired nationalism was already part of monks' riots in the 1920s and 1930s. There are also reports of occasional anti-Muslim violence over the period of the Ne Win and SLORC/SPDC governments. Egreteau (2011) argues that contemporary 'Islamophobia' has developed as a broader 'Indophobia' — Indians were perceived as agents of the colonial regime — and was reduced to its anti-Muslim direction over the last period of the military regime.

New freedom of expression, coupled with the use of new technologies, led to an increase in religiously framed political hate speech, both offline and online (see Schissler 2016), prior to the electoral contest. The major protagonists were religiously conservative and extremist monks such as Ashin Wirathu, who was convicted for political instigation in 2003, but was released along with other political prisoners in 2012. Since 2012, the increase in anti-Muslim sentiment became visible in public space with the emergence of the 969 movement and its Buy Buddhist campaign. The political policy agenda of the Organization for the Protection of Race and Religion, known by its abbreviation MaBaTha, founded in early 2014, started to target the legislature more directly with the propagation of four laws relating to interreligious marriage, religious conversion, monogamy, and population control (Walton and Hayward 2014, pp. 12–16). Acknowledging that these movements are "a reflexive defense against what is perceived by some to be the threat of a globally spreading Islam, as well as the motivation to preserve and promote Buddhist practice and behavior in Myanmar during a time of significant change", Walton and Hayward (2014, p. x) argue that they are inherently political in nature.

Ahead of the elections, the political process appeared increasingly held